

Absolutely — **exam** is useful, but unlike words such as *good*, *human*, or *treat*, the bare word **exam** itself does **not** have a huge number of genuinely separate meanings. Under our Golden Manual, I would **not force artificial polysemy** here.

The real learning value comes from the broader family:

Word family: **exam / examination / examine / examiner / examinee**

Base word: exam

Full form: examination

Verb: examine

Person nouns: examiner, examinee

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / related verb and person nouns (相關動詞及人物名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Before meeting him, I used to think studying meant memorising facts and repeating them in **exams**.”

Meaning in your passage: **exam = formal test of knowledge/ability — 考試 ; 測驗**

Here, **exam** means:

> **a formal test used to measure a student’s knowledge, understanding, or ability in a subject.**

繁體中文 :

用來正式評核學生對某科目知識、理解或能力的考試

Natural translation:

> “I used to think studying meant memorising facts and repeating them in exams.”

「我以前一直以為讀書就是背誦資料，然後在**考試**中把那些內容重複寫出來。」

So here:

> **exam = 正式評核學習成果的考試**

1. **exam = academic test (學校 / 大學) — 考試 ; 測驗**

This is your exact original sense and overwhelmingly the most common meaning of bare **exam**.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I used to think studying meant memorising facts and repeating them in **exams**.”

「我以前以為讀書就是背資料，然後在**考試**中把內容重複寫出來。」

Practice 2

> “We have a history **exam** next Monday.”

「我們下星期一有一場歷史**考試**。」

Practice 3

> “She studied all weekend for the final **exam**.”

「她整個週末都在準備期末**考試**。」

exam = 用問題、題目或實際任務正式評核學生知識、理解或能力的測驗

2. **exam** = professional/qualification test (專業 / 資格) — 資格考試；專業考試

This is not really a different lexical concept from #1; it is the same **formal assessment** concept in another setting.

Practice 4

> “He is preparing for his driving theory **exam**.”

「他正在準備駕駛理論**考試**。」

Practice 5

> “She passed her professional accounting **exams**.”

「她通過了專業會計**資格考試**。」

exam — qualification context = 用來判定某人是否符合專業、牌照或資格要求的正式測試

I would keep this under the same broad sense as academic exams rather than pretend it is a separate meaning.

3. **exam = medical examination (醫療檢查) — 身體檢查 ; 醫療檢查**

This is a genuinely important second use of **exam**, especially in American English.

Practice 6

> “The doctor performed a physical **exam**.”

「醫生進行了**身體檢查**。」

Practice 7

> “You should have an eye **exam** once a year.”

「你應該每年進行一次**眼睛檢查 / 視力檢查**。」

exam — medicine = 由醫護人員檢查身體、眼睛、牙齒等，以評估健康狀況

Common:

* physical exam

* eye exam

* dental exam

* medical exam

This is the clearest major non-academic meaning of bare **exam**.

4. **examination = academic/professional test — 考試 ; 正式測驗**

Examination is the full, more formal form of **exam**.

Practice 8

> “Candidates must complete the written **examination**.”

「考生必須完成筆試**考試**。」

Practice 9

> “The final examination accounts for half of the course grade.”

「期末**考試**佔課程成績的一半。」

examination = 正式用來評核知識、技能或資格的測試

Register:

> **exam** = everyday/common

> **examination** = more formal

5. **examination** = careful inspection/investigation (仔細檢查 / 研究) — 檢查 ; 審視 ; 研究

This is where **examination** becomes broader than ordinary **exam**.

Practice 10

> “A close **examination** of the evidence revealed several problems.”

「對證據進行仔細**審視 / 檢查**後，發現了幾個問題。」

Practice 11

> “The report includes an examination of the causes of the conflict.”

「報告包括對衝突原因的**深入分析 / 探討**。」

examination = 對某個物件、證據、問題或議題進行仔細、系統的檢查 / 研究

Important:

Bare **exam** is usually **not** used this broadly in formal academic prose.

6. **examination** = medical inspection (醫療) — 檢查 ; 診察

Practice 12

> “The doctor carried out a full medical **examination**.”

「醫生進行了一次完整的**身體檢查**。」

Practice 13

> “Further examination showed no serious injury.”

「進一步**檢查**顯示沒有嚴重受傷。」

****examination — medicine = 醫護人員透過觀察、測試或診察評估身體狀況****

7. ****examine + student/candidate (考核) — 考核；測驗****

Now we move to the verb.

Practice 14

> “Students are ****examined**** in both history and geography.”

「學生在歷史和地理兩科都會接受****考核****。」

Practice 15

> “The course examines students through written and oral tests.”

「這門課透過筆試和口試****考核學生****。」

****examine someone = 正式測試某人的知識、能力或資格****

This is less common in everyday school conversation than:

> test someone

but is standard formal English.

8. ****examine + object/person (仔細查看) — 仔細檢查；察看****

A major verb meaning.

Practice 16

> “The scientist ****examined**** the sample under a microscope.”

「科學家在顯微鏡下仔細****檢查****樣本。」

Practice 17

> “The doctor ****examined**** his knee.”

「醫生仔細****檢查 / 診察****他的膝蓋。」

****examine = 仔細觀察或檢查某人 / 某物，以找出細節、問題或證據****

9. ****examine + issue/idea/evidence (議題 / 證據) — 審視；研究；分析****

A common academic meaning.

Practice 18

> “The essay ****examines**** the causes of the war.”

「這篇文章****分析 / 探討****戰爭的成因。」

Practice 19

> “We need to ****examine the evidence**** carefully.”

「我們需要仔細****審視證據****。」

****examine an issue = 對某個議題、證據或觀點進行仔細分析，以理解其性質、原因或可信程度****

10. ****examiner = person who sets/marks/conducts an exam — 考官；評核員****

Practice 20

> “The ****examiner**** asked several follow-up questions.”

「****考官****問了幾條跟進問題。」

Practice 21

> “The oral examiner assessed the candidate’s speaking ability.”

「口試****考官****評核考生的說話能力。」

****examiner = 負責出題、主持、監考或評核考試 / 測試的人****

Context determines whether Chinese is:

* 考官

* 評核員

* 主考人

11. **examiner = person who inspects/investigates professionally — 檢驗員；審查人員**

The person noun also appears beyond school exams.

Practice 22

> “The medical **examiner** investigated the cause of death.”

「法醫 / **驗屍官**調查死因。」

Practice 23

> “The patent examiner reviewed the application.”

「專利**審查員**審核了申請。」

examiner = 專業上負責仔細檢查、審核或評估某事物的人

Natural Chinese changes by profession.

12. **examinee = person taking an exam — 應試者；考生**

Practice 24

> “Each **examinee** was given thirty minutes.”

「每名**考生 / 應試者**獲得三十分鐘。」

Practice 25

> “Examinees must show identification before entering the room.”

「**應試者**進入試場前必須出示身分證明。」

examinee = 正在接受考試、測驗或正式評核的人

Register: formal.

In everyday school English, **candidate** or **student** may be more natural depending on context.

Useful compound: **exam paper**

Practice 26

> “Turn over the **exam paper** when instructed.”

「收到指示後才翻開**試卷**。」

Practice 27

> “The exam paper contained six questions.”

「**試卷**共有六條問題。」

exam paper = 載有考試題目的試卷

In British English, very common.

Useful compound: **final exam**

Practice 28

> “The final **exam** is in June.”

「期末**考試**在六月舉行。」

Practice 29

> “She revised hard for her final exams.”

「她為期末**考試**努力溫習。」

final exam = 在課程 / 學期末進行的重要考試

You already curated **final**, so I would not reopen that family here.

Useful compound: **entrance exam**

Practice 30

> “Applicants must take an **entrance exam**.”

「申請人必須參加**入學考試**。」

Practice 31

> “He passed the school entrance exam.”

「他通過了學校的**入學試**。」

****entrance exam = 用來決定某人是否能進入學校、課程或機構的考試****

Useful compound: ****oral exam****

Practice 32

> “The language course includes an ****oral exam****.”

「語言課程包括****口試****。」

Practice 33

> “She was nervous before the oral exam.”

「她在****口試****前很緊張。」

****oral exam = 主要透過說話和回答問題進行的考試****

Important distinction: ****exam vs examination****

****exam****

shorter, everyday.

> “I have an exam tomorrow.”

「我明天有考試。」

****examination****

more formal and broader.

It can mean:

- * an exam;
- * medical examination;
- * careful investigation/analysis.

So:

- > **exam** is usually narrower.
- > **examination** is semantically broader.

Important distinction: **exam vs test**

exam

usually:

- * more formal;
- * larger;
- * often important for grades/qualification.

test

broader and can be smaller/informal.

- > “We have a vocabulary test tomorrow.”

could be a short classroom assessment.

- > “We have a final exam next month.”

usually sounds larger and more formal.

The boundary varies by education system.

Important distinction: **exam vs quiz**

quiz

usually shorter and lower-stakes.

exam

usually more formal and substantial.

> quiz = 小測

> exam = 考試

Especially in North American education, this distinction is common.

Important distinction: **exam vs assessment**

exam

one specific testing event.

assessment

broader process of evaluating performance.

Assessment can include:

- * exams;
- * coursework;
- * projects;
- * presentations;
- * participation.

So:

> **an exam is a type of assessment**

but not every assessment is an exam.

Important distinction: **examine vs check**

check

broad everyday word:

look to make sure something is correct/okay.

examine

more careful/systematic.

> “Check your answer.”

「檢查答案。」

> “Examine the evidence.”

「仔細審視證據。」

****Examine**** implies deeper inspection.

Important distinction: ****examine vs inspect****

****examine****

focuses on careful observation/analysis.

****inspect****

often implies an official or systematic check against standards.

> examine a patient

> inspect a building

There is overlap, but typical contexts differ.

Important distinction: ****examine vs analyse****

****examine****

= look closely at something.

****analyse****

= break it into parts/relationships to understand how or why it works.

> “Examine the evidence.”

「仔細審視證據。」

> “Analyse the causes.”

「分析原因。」

Academic writing often uses both.

Important distinction: **examiner** vs **examinee**

A classic **-er** / **-ee** contrast.

examiner

= person doing the examining

「考官」

examinee

= person being examined

「考生 / 應試者」

Compare:

> interviewer / interviewee

> employer / employee

The **-ee** form often refers to the receiver/target of the action.

Countability note: **exam**

Exam is countable.

> one exam

> two exams

> several exams

Correct:

> “I have three exams next week.”

Not:

> “I have much exam.” ✗

Family-extension sweep

After the full audit, the useful modern family includes:

* **exam — academic/professional** = 正式考試 / 資格考試
* **exam — medical** = 身體 / 醫療檢查
* **examination — test** = 正式考試
* **examination — close study** = 仔細檢查 / 審視 / 研究
* **examination — medical** = 診察 / 身體檢查
* **examine — assess knowledge** = 考核
* **examine — inspect** = 仔細檢查
* **examine — analyse issue/evidence** = 審視 / 分析
* **examiner — assessment** = 考官 / 評核員
* **examiner — professional inspection** = 審查員 / 檢驗人員
* **examinee** = 考生 / 應試者
* **exam paper** = 試卷
* **final exam** = 期末考試
* **entrance exam** = 入學考試
* **oral exam** = 口試

And importantly, under our Golden Manual:

> **bare exam itself has only a small number of genuinely useful modern meanings.**

Its main polysemy is essentially:

1. **formal test**
2. **medical examination**

Most of the richer semantic expansion comes from **examination / examine**, so I would not manufacture ten fake senses of **exam** just because its compounds occur in different contexts.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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exam — academic/professional	用問題或任務正式評核某人的知識、理解、技能或資格的考試
exam — medical	由醫護人員檢查身體 / 某身體部位以評估健康狀況
examination — formal test	較正式地指評核知識、技能或資格的考試
examination — close inspection	對物件、證據、問題或議題進行仔細、系統的檢查 / 研究

examination — medical	醫護人員透過觀察、測試或診察評估身體狀況	
examine — test someone	正式測試某人的知識、能力或資格	
examine — inspect	仔細觀察或檢查某人 / 某物以找出細節或問題	
examine — academic	仔細分析某個議題、證據或觀點	
examiner — exam	負責主持、出題或評核考試的人	
examiner — professional	在專業上負責檢查、審核或評估某事物的人	
examinee	正在接受考試或正式評核的人	
exam paper	載有考試題目的試卷	
entrance exam	用來決定是否能進入學校 / 課程的入學考試	
oral exam	主要以口頭回答問題方式進行的考試	

For your original sentence

> “Before meeting him, I used to think studying meant memorising facts and repeating them in
exams.”

The exact meaning is:

****exam = 用來正式評核學生對學科知識和能力的考試****

So:

> ****repeating them in exams****

= ****「在考試中把背熟的資料重新寫出來」****

Natural full translation:

> ****「在認識他之前，我一直以為讀書就是背誦資料，然後在考試中把那些內容重複寫出來。」****

And this is one of those cases where our conservative rule matters: ****exam** is useful, but its bare-word polysemy is relatively compact.** The broader ****examine / examination**** family is where the semantic richness really appears.